for revenge against his enemy. The *Iqbalnama* also says that Abdun Nabi had spent his time in Mecca spreading tales of Akbar and his heresies, and that this was the real cause of Akbar's anger against him (Translator's note in *The Akbarnama of Abu'l Fazl*, vol. 3).

. Later, the Father goes further, writing that Akbar's treatment of his nobility was such that each one 'believes himself to be regarded not only as a contemptible creature but as the very lowest and meanest of mankind'. See Fr. Antonio Monserrate, *The Commentary of Father Monserrate, S.J. on his Journey to the Court of Akbar*, trans. J.S. Hoyland, annotations S.N. Banerjee (Oxford University Press, 1922).

. The 'vassal' was Muzaffar Mirza of Qandahar. Decades ago, when Akbar gained his precarious throne, the Mughals had had to let Qandahar revert to Shah Tahmasp (who would have argued, of course, that they had no claim to the city in the first place, since it was taken for Humayun by the shah's troops led by his infant son). It speaks volumes for the rising Mughal star that, in 1595, Qandahar submitted to Akbar without a shot being fired – Muzaffar Mirza came to court and meekly accepted a mansab of 5000 in Sambhal ('which is larger than Qandahar', as Abul Fazl doesn't fail to note).

. Du Jarric, *Akbar and the Jesuits: An Account of the Jesuit Missions to the Court of Akbar*. To this day, it is not uncommon for visitors to Akbar's grave in Sikandra to leave a small offering of money, just as worshippers do at shrines of many faiths across the subcontinent.

. Ibid.

. *The Ain-i-Akbari*, vol. 1.

. *The Ain-i-Akbari*, vol. 3. Akbar's antipathy towards meat would reach such an extent, in fact, that he also declared that 'Butchers, fishermen and the like who have no other occupation but taking life should have a separate quarter and their association with others would be prohibited by fine'. For weeks on end, Akbar would eat no meat, or only a little for 'the spirit of the age' (*The Ain-i-Akbari*, vol. 1).

. Famously, Akbar only drank water from the Ganga, although Abul Fazl may have had a slight preference for the Yamuna's water, of which he wrote that it 'has few like it for . . . lightness and digestibility'. *The Akbarnama of Abu'l Fazl*, vol. 2.

. *The Ain-i-Akbari*, vol. 1.

. Nizamuddin Ahmad, *Tabakat-i Akbari*.

. Monserrate, *The Commentary of Father Monserrate*.

. Ibid.

. The weighing ceremony, *majlis-i-wazn* (Nizamuddin, *Tabakat-i Akbari*), may have been borrowed from the Indian custom of *tula-daan*. The *Akbarnama* mentions such weighing ceremonies on Akbar's lunar birthdays in previous years, but it was now, in 1582, that he added a solar birthday ceremony to his calendar – and, perhaps, began to observe the custom more publicly.

. Iqtidar Alam Khan, *The Political Biography of a Mughal Noble: Mun'im Khan Khan-i Khanan, 1497–1575* (Orient Longman, 1973).

. The emperor wasn't just dispossessing the high-ranking and powerful officials in his realm, however; he was, once again, reinforcing them in their place with regard to the throne. As J.F. Richards argues, escheat was '[c]ontrary to the precepts of canonical law for the inheritance of free Muslims, but permissible of course for slaves' – that is, when Akbar took over an amir's property, he was confirming his nobility's 'enslavement' to the throne. See J.F. Richards, 'The Formulation of Imperial Authority under Akbar and Jahangir', in *The Mughal State: 1526–1750*, eds Muzaffar Alam and Sanjay Subrahmanyam (Oxford University Press, 1998).

. *The Akbarnama of Abu'l Fazl*, vol. 3.

. Birbar and Abul Fazl may have been playing to another facet of Akbar's personality with their suggestions: Birbar proposed men spread across the realm sending secret reports to court; Abul Fazl